

useful for developers, testers and advanced users. It is also a favourite doorway for scams.

Search Install unknown apps or Unknown app installs in Settings. Review which apps are allowed to install APKs. Ideally, none should have this permission permanently. If you temporarily grant it to a browser or file manager, revoke it after installing the trusted APK.

Never install APKs from forwarded WhatsApp messages, random Telegram channels, fake customer-care links, movie piracy sites, betting groups or “urgent KYC update” pages. If someone on a call asks you to install an app to “verify” banking, SIM, courier or refund details, stop. The issue is no longer convenience. It is risk.

App behaviour: battery, background and data

Permissions are only part of privacy. App behaviour also matters. Some apps run in the background, consume data, wake frequently, track activity, send notifications and sync constantly. This affects battery, performance and attention.

Open Settings > Apps and inspect suspicious apps. Check battery usage, mobile data usage, notification settings and permissions. If an app uses too much background data or battery without clear reason, restrict it or uninstall it. But be careful with messaging, email, authenticator, calendar, payments and security apps; aggressive restrictions can delay important alerts.

Privacy and usability must be balanced. Do not turn your phone into a locked box that fails at useful work. The goal is controlled access.

Step-by-step: inspect one suspicious app

- Open Settings.
- Tap Apps.
- Choose the app.
- Open Permissions and remove unnecessary access.
- Open Mobile data and check background data use.
- Open Battery and check whether it has unusual activity.
- Open Notifications and turn off promotional channels.
- Tap App details in store, if available, and review the Play Store listing.
- Uninstall the app if the behaviour does not match the value it provides.

Do this whenever an app feels strange, noisy, battery-hungry or overly curious.

Children, parents and shared phones

Privacy also changes when phones are shared. Many Indian households have phones used by parents, children, siblings, shop staff or temporary users. In such cases, app locks, separate user profiles where supported, guest mode, restricted permissions and careful notification settings become more important.

If a parent uses the phone, simplify permission decisions. Remove unnecessary apps. Keep only trusted payment and communication apps. Hide sensitive notification content. Turn on Play Protect. Avoid giving browser or file manager permission to install unknown apps.

If a child uses the phone, use parental controls and age-appropriate app access. Do not rely only on scolding. Configure the device. Digital safety is design, not merely discipline.



Android 16 and privacy direction

Android privacy keeps evolving. Google’s Android 16 summary says Android 16 incorporates the latest version of Privacy Sandbox on Android as part of work to develop technologies where users know their privacy is protected. Google’s developer blog also described Android 16 as continuing its mission to improve security and ensure user privacy.

For readers, the exact developer APIs matter less than the direction: Android is moving toward more transparency, more limits, and more user control. But no platform update can fix careless approval. Even the best privacy system fails if users keep pressing Allow without thinking.

Your monthly privacy reset

Once a month, do a 20-minute privacy reset.

Open Privacy Dashboard. Check camera, microphone and location access. Open Permission Manager. Review location, contacts, SMS and files. Check unknown app installs. Remove apps you have not used in months. Review Play Store Data safety before keeping unfamiliar apps. Check lock-screen notification privacy. Look at battery and data usage for strange behaviour.

Then ask a brutal question: does this app still deserve to live on my phone?

That is the heart of Android privacy. Not fear. Not conspiracy. Not pretending that every app is evil. Simply insisting that access must be earned. **fi**